

Edinburgh, City of Literature - Kids

UK Family Tour

The City That's Famous for Stories

Here is something almost unbelievable. A whole city can win a prize for stories, and this is the city that won it first. In the year two thousand and four, Edinburgh became the very first City of Literature in the entire world. That is a fancy way of saying the number one city on the planet for books and writers. Nobody had ever won it before, because Edinburgh invented the whole idea.

Now here is the truly amazing part. Scotland is a small country, with fewer people in the whole of it than live in lots of single cities. And yet, so many of the stories you already know were dreamed up right here, on the very streets your feet are walking today.

Just think about it. The most exciting pirate story ever written, with a treasure map and a sly one-legged villain, was invented here. The world's greatest detective, a man who can look at a total stranger and tell you their whole life, was invented here. And a boy wizard with a lightning scar on his forehead, well, a huge amount of his story was written in cafes just around the corner from where you are standing right now.

So why here? Part of it is that Edinburgh has always been crammed full of printing machines and books and clever people, all arguing in tiny streets. Hundreds of years ago they even printed the very first Encyclopaedia right here, one of those giant sets of books that tries to explain absolutely everything in the world.

But part of it is the city itself, because Edinburgh has two faces, almost like a person with a secret. On one side there is the Old Town, dark and twisty and crowded, full of narrow little alleys called closes that dive off the main street like rabbit holes. And across a valley there is the New Town, all neat and tidy and grand. One city, two completely different faces. Keep that idea safe in your pocket, because it turns out to be the secret behind one of the spookiest stories of all. Ready to meet the writers? Come on.

The Poet Everyone Sings

I bet you have sung a song written by this man, and I bet you had absolutely no idea. Have you ever been somewhere on New Year's Eve, when the clock hits midnight, and suddenly everybody grabs hands in a big circle and sings a song that nobody quite knows the words to? Something about should old acquaintance be forgot? That song is called Auld Lang Syne, and it was made by a Scottish poet named Robert Burns, more than two hundred years ago. It is sung at New Year in country after country, all around the whole world. Your parents have sung it. So have you, probably. And now you know whose song it is.

Robert Burns is so important to Scotland that people here call him simply the Bard, which is an old word for a great poet, and they treat him almost like a king made of words. Here is why. Long ago, posh people thought the ordinary Scottish way of talking, which is called Scots, was not fancy enough for poetry. Burns proved them completely wrong. He wrote in the real, everyday words that farmers and

families actually used, and he made them beautiful. He was a farm boy himself, born in a tiny cottage, and he wrote some of his greatest poems with mud on his boots and cold hands.

When he was a young man, he came here to Edinburgh with just one small book of poems, and the whole city went wild for him. Suddenly this farmer was being invited to grand dinners by dukes and professors, everybody wanting to meet the ploughman who could write like an angel.

Now here is something to remember for later in your trip. Burns wrote a fierce, brave poem, pretending to be the great warrior king Robert the Bruce, giving his soldiers a speech before a huge battle against the English at a place called Bannockburn, near Stirling. When you visit that part of Scotland, remember that the most famous version of that battle speech was written by a gentle farmer poet, hundreds of years after the real battle happened.

And here is the most fun bit of all. Every single year, on Burns's birthday, Scottish people all over the world throw him a giant birthday dinner, even though he lived and died centuries ago. Bagpipes play, and somebody carries in a haggis, which is a big round Scottish sort of sausage pudding. And here is the silly part. A person stands up and reads a big dramatic poem out loud, to the haggis, as if the dinner could hear them. And guess what, Burns wrote that poem too. Imagine being such a good writer that people are still singing your songs and reading your poems to their supper, hundreds of years after you are gone.

The Writer With a Train Station Named After Him

Here is a way to tell if a writer was truly, enormously famous. Did a whole city name its biggest train station after one of their books? For Sir Walter Scott, the answer is yes. When you come into the middle of Edinburgh on a train, you arrive at a station called Waverley. And Waverley is the name of a book that Scott wrote, way back in eighteen fourteen. People think it is the only train station in the whole world named after a made-up story. Imagine being so famous that trains full of people pull into a station named after your book, every single day, hundreds of years after you wrote it.

In his own time, Walter Scott might have been the most famous writer alive anywhere on Earth. People all over the world gobbled up his books, especially the ones packed with knights, castles, battles and heroes. His book *Ivanhoe* has jousting knights on galloping horses, and even Robin Hood turns up in it. He was so good at spinning these tales that people gave him a brilliant nickname. They called him the Wizard of the North.

But now for my favourite Walter Scott story, because it is a real-life treasure hunt. Scotland has its very own crown jewels, a golden crown, a sword and a royal sceptre, and they are even older than the crown jewels down in London. But here is the strange thing. Long ago they had been locked away in a hidden room in Edinburgh Castle, and then, unbelievably, everyone forgot about them, for more than a hundred years. Nobody alive had ever seen them. Some people wondered if they even still existed, or if they had been stolen away.

Walter Scott could not bear the mystery. So he got special permission from the king himself to go and look. And one day in eighteen eighteen, he stood and watched as workers smashed their way into a sealed old room in the castle, blew the dust off an ancient locked chest, and slowly lifted the lid. And there they were. The lost crown jewels of Scotland, sitting exactly where they had been left a hundred years before. If you saw them sparkling behind glass up at the castle, it was a storyteller, Walter Scott, who found them again.

When you are walking along Princes Street, look up for his monument. It is a giant black stone spire, pointed at the top like a rocket, more than sixty metres tall, with a white marble statue of Scott sitting underneath it. And because he loved his dog so much, his dog is carved right there beside him. It might just be the biggest monument to any writer anywhere in the world. Not bad for a man whose whole job was making up stories.

The Spooky Secret Behind Jekyll and Hyde

You might already know that a writer from Edinburgh called Robert Louis Stevenson wrote *Treasure Island*, the greatest pirate story of all, with the treasure map and the sneaky one-legged Long John Silver. But now I want to tell you about a different story of his, a much spookier one, and the creepy real-life secret hiding behind it.

The story is called *Doctor Jekyll and Mister Hyde*. It is about a kind, gentle, respectable doctor named Doctor Jekyll, who invents a strange bubbling potion. When he drinks it, something horrible happens. He changes into a completely different person, a cruel and frightening man called Mister Hyde, who creeps about doing wicked things in the dark. And little by little, the good doctor starts to lose control of when he turns into the monster. One person, but two different selves, one good and one bad, hiding inside the very same body. It is such a famous idea that even today, if someone is friendly one minute and horrible the next, people say they are a bit Jekyll and Hyde.

So where did Stevenson get such a shivery idea? Remember the secret I told you to keep in your pocket, that Edinburgh is a city with two faces? Well, this is where it matters. Stevenson grew up in the neat, posh part of the city, but just a short walk away were the dark, twisty old alleys full of secrets. A city with a polite face and a hidden face. He knew both of them well.

But here is the really spine-tingling part. Edinburgh once had a real man who lived exactly like Jekyll and Hyde. His name was Deacon Brodie. In the daytime, Brodie was as respectable as could be. He made beautiful wooden furniture, he sat on the town council, and everybody trusted him. But at night, he turned into something else. A burglar. He would sneak out and rob the houses of the very same people who had invited him in for dinner, because he was clever with locks and he knew all their secrets. In the end he was caught, and the story goes that he was even hanged on a set of gallows that he himself had once helped to build, though nobody is quite sure if that last part is really true.

And now for the shiver right down your spine. Stevenson's family owned a wooden cabinet, a kind of tall cupboard, and it had been made by Deacon Brodie's very own hands. And it stood right there in young Robert's bedroom. So as a boy, Stevenson fell asleep every single night next to furniture built by a man who was respectable by day and a criminal by night. Is it any wonder that he grew up and wrote a story about a man with two hidden selves? Sometimes the scariest stories grow right out of the writer's own bedroom.

The Real Man Who Could Read Your Life

Have you ever heard of Sherlock Holmes, the world's cleverest detective, with his funny hat and his magnifying glass? His most amazing trick is this. He can look at a person he has never met before, just for a few seconds, and then tell them exactly what job they do, where they have just been, and what they did that very morning, all without being told a single thing. It seems like pure magic. Well, here is a secret. Sherlock Holmes was invented right here in Edinburgh, and the man who could really do that trick was completely real.

The writer who created Sherlock was called Arthur Conan Doyle, and he was born in this very city. When he was young, he studied hard to become a doctor at the university here. And one of his teachers was an incredible man named Doctor Joseph Bell. Doctor Bell had a habit that left his students with their mouths hanging wide open.

A patient he had never met would walk into the room. And before the person even opened their mouth to say what was wrong with them, Doctor Bell would look them up and down for just a moment, and then say something like, you have been a soldier, haven't you, and you were recently in a hot country, and you walked here past the harbour this morning. And the patient would gasp, because it was all true. How on

earth did he do it? Not magic. He just noticed things. Tiny, tiny things. The way the person stood up straight like a soldier. A patch of sunburn on their skin. A speck of a certain kind of mud on their boots that only came from down by the sea. Everything was there to be seen, if only you really, truly looked. Doctor Bell always told his students, use your eyes, use your eyes.

Young Arthur never forgot it. Years later, when he decided to write a detective story, he thought of his old teacher and those astonishing eyes, and he built a hero who solved crimes in exactly the same way, by noticing the tiny clues that everybody else walked straight past. He named him Sherlock Holmes. In the very first story, Holmes meets his friend Doctor Watson for the first time, takes one single look at him, and announces that Watson has just come back from a war in Afghanistan, which turns out to be exactly right. Readers loved it, and they have loved it ever since.

So here is something to try yourself, today. Be a little bit Sherlock. Look at the people walking past on the Royal Mile, and see what you can guess about them just by looking. What are they carrying? What are they wearing? Where might they be hurrying off to? You will be surprised how much your eyes can tell you, if you really use them. That is the whole secret of the greatest detective in the world, and it was learned right here in Edinburgh.

The Cafes Where Harry Potter Was Written

Now for the writer you have probably been waiting for this whole time. Because some of the most famous books in the entire world, about a boy wizard with a lightning scar named Harry Potter, were written right here in Edinburgh. And the story of how they were written is almost as good as the books themselves.

Back in the nineteen nineties, a young mum named Joanne Rowling did not have very much money at all. Her flat was cold, and warming it up cost money that she simply did not have. So she would wrap up her baby daughter, tuck her snugly into a pushchair, and walk to a warm cafe. And there, while her baby slept, she would sit for hours over one single cup of coffee, scribbling in her notebooks, dreaming up a school for wizards, a game played on flying broomsticks, and a boy who did not yet know that he was magic. Bit by bit, in cafes around this city, Harry Potter came to life. Just imagine that. One of the biggest stories in the whole world, written by a tired mum with a sleeping baby and a cold cup of coffee.

Now, here is where you have to be a good detective, just like Sherlock, and tell the difference between what is really true and what is only a fun story that fans have made up. It is true that Rowling wrote a lot of Harry Potter in Edinburgh cafes. But fans have added all sorts of extra tales on top, and not all of them are proven.

For example, there is an old graveyard nearby called Greyfriars Kirkyard, full of ancient, mossy, tilting gravestones. And fans love to hunt for one particular stone, because it has the name Thomas Riddell carved on it, which sounds an awful lot like Tom Riddle, the real name of the villain Voldemort. Spooky, right? And right beside the graveyard stands a gorgeous old school with pointy towers, called George Heriot's, and lots of fans are sure it gave Rowling her idea for Hogwarts, with its towers and its different houses. But here is the honest truth. Those are fan ideas. Rowling herself has never said that is where she got the names or the castle, so they might just be happy coincidences. It is great fun to look for them, as long as you remember it is a maybe, and not a definitely.

And Rowling is not the only modern writer here. Edinburgh is so stuffed full of storytellers that grown-ups have whole shelves of exciting detective books set right in these streets, full of mysteries and crimes to solve, written by authors who love this city just as much as Burns and Stevenson did, all those years ago.

So look around you one more time. Poets, pirates, detectives, monsters, and wizards, all dreamed up in this one small, steep, twisty, story-soaked city. You have been walking straight through the pages of the whole world's bookshelf. That is pretty magical, for a place made of stone.